Every blanket-wafer ALD recipe hides a 40× under-dose: a chamber-to-feature model of supply-limited atomic layer deposition*

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Abstract

ALD recipes are tuned on blanket wafers. Product wafers are not blank: a 3D-NAND array of 100 nm holes at aspect ratio 100 carries 56 times the surface area of the wafer under it, and all of it has to saturate in one pulse. We built a model of a 300 mm showerhead ALD chamber in which every point on the wafer runs its own feature-scale model of a hole, coupled both ways to the chamber gas, and asked how long the pulse must be. The answer is a single rule: the saturating pulse equals 1.2 times (1 + patterned area ratio) times the time the showerhead needs to deliver one monolayer of precursor. It held within 25 % across aspect ratios 20 to 100 and a twenty-fold range of precursor feed; on non-uniform layouts the local wall-area ratio of the densest region sets the pulse, not the wafer average. At a typical operating point the blanket wafer saturates in 0.35 s and the product wafer in 14 s. Chamber pressure, showerhead gap and carrier flow do not move that number; precursor delivery rate does. Nor does the sticking coefficient across its published range; only the blanket pulse does, threefold. The water half-cycle, fifty times less reactive, needs the same pulse on the product wafer and coats it more evenly. The feature model agrees with an independent Argonne code to 7 % and fits published thickness profiles from lateral test structures, and the rule itself reproduces the measured saturation time of a fluidized-bed ALD run on 940 m^2 of silica gel to 7 %. The rule turns a day of recipe transfer into arithmetic, and says where a tool's throughput actually comes from.

What this means for a tool (one paragraph for the process engineer). If your recipe was saturated on a monitor wafer, multiply the pulse by one plus the product wafer's wall-area ratio before you trust it on product. Size the pulse on the densest or deepest region's own wall-area ratio; the wafer average under-doses it. Pressure, gap and carrier flow are uniformity knobs; they buy no time. Time comes from precursor molecules per second: vapour pressure, bubbler flow, injector design, or an architecture that exposes the wafer to a denser zone (spatial ALD wins by the same factor the rule predicts). Low-sticking reactants are not the bottleneck on patterned wafers; their cost is on blanket wafers only. And when the deepest feature saturates, the chamber shows it: the precursor stops being consumed and appears downstream. On a 3D-NAND wafer the pulses are three quarters of the cycle and the purges a quarter, the reverse of the blanket wafer, so the throughput lever is precursor delivery and the purge lever is water desorption, not chamber flow.

*Draft 0.9.2 (public), 10 November 2026. Every number is from a run documented in the repository run log, `paper/assumptions.md`.

1 Introduction

Three facts set up the problem. First, 3D NAND and DRAM are built from features with aspect ratios of 50 to 100, and ALD is the only way to coat their insides [16, 17], so the precursor must reach the bottom of every feature on the wafer inside a single pulse. Second, the patterned surface area of such a wafer is tens of times the wafer area, so the wafer consumes precursor tens of times faster than the blank wafer the recipe was developed on. Third, nobody models these two things together: feature-scale conformality models [1, 2, 4, 8] assume the precursor density at the feature mouth is given, and chamber models assume the wafer's uptake is given. The quantity that matters, the gas density at the wafer surface while the wafer is eating it, falls between the two.

This paper closes that gap with a model small enough to run on a laptop and checked hard enough to trust. A chamber flow model carries, on every wafer face, a feature-scale model of a hole; the two exchange precursor every time step. The feature model is verified against an independent ballistic code and fitted to published measurements. The result is not a simulation to be rerun for every recipe but a rule: pulse time is set by precursor supply and patterned area, and by nothing else that a chamber recipe normally adjusts.

Equipment makers are building exactly this class of model under the name of equipment-and-process digital twins [15]. This work is an open, reproducible instance for ALD, with every case file, boundary condition and figure in the repository.

Contributions: (i) a two-way coupled chamber–feature wall condition for OpenFOAM, released; (ii) two-code verification and public-data validation of the feature model; (iii) the supply-limit rule and its range of validity; (iv) the blanket-to-product recipe-transfer factor, the shielding mechanism and the edge-lag inversion; (v) the temporal-versus-spatial design chart and the plasma-ALD recombination ceiling.

2 Model

2.1 Chamber

Axisymmetric showerhead chamber, 300 mm wafer, 15 mm gap, 200 mm chamber radius, annular outlet. N_2 carrier at 300 Pa, 573 K ($\rho = 1.76 \times 10^{-3}\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}$, $\nu = 1.65 \times 10^{-2}\,\mathrm{m^2/s}$), 300 sccm (0.050 m/s at the showerhead face), Re = 0.045, residence time 0.53 s. Steady laminar flow (`simpleFoam`, OpenFOAM v2606 [19]), frozen for the species step. TMA as a passive scalar c/c_0, $D = 8.4 \times 10^{-3}\,\mathrm{m^2/s}$ at 300 Pa (Chapman–Enskog scaling), gap Péclet number 0.09. Inlet: Danckwerts total-flux condition

$$U\,(c_{\mathrm{face}} - c_0) = D\,\frac{c_{\mathrm{face}} - c_{\mathrm{cell}}}{\delta}. \tag{1}$$

We show that a fixed-concentration inlet over-injects by 11× at this Péclet number (Section 3.1).

2.2 Wafer boundary condition (concurrent multiscale)

Flat surface: irreversible Langmuir,

$$\frac{d\theta}{dt} = \frac{\bar{v}}{4}\,s\,(1-\theta)\,\frac{c_s}{N_0}. \tag{2}$$

Holes: cylinder of diameter d and aspect ratio AR, Knudsen diffusivity $d\bar{v}/3$, quasi-steady gas [4] with sink $(\bar{v}/d)\,[\,s\,(1-\theta(x)) + r\,]$, coverage advanced per cell; mouth density equals the local wafer-surface gas density c_s. Net uptake per unit wafer area

$$K_{\mathrm{eff}}\,c_s = (1-\phi) \times \text{flat uptake} + \phi \times \text{hole-mouth Knudsen flux}, \tag{3}$$

ϕ the open-area fraction. Implemented as an OpenFOAM mixed condition with value fraction $K_{\text{eff}}/(K_{\text{eff}} + D/\delta)$. Parameters: $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$ (TMA) and 10^{-4} (H_2O) [5], $N_0 = 4 \times 10^{18}\,\text{m}^{-2}$, $\bar{v}$ from kinetic theory at 573 K, $d = 100$ nm, hole density $1.78 \times 10^{13}\,\text{m}^{-2}$ (180 nm hexagonal pitch, 50 % of the wafer patterned): open area 14 %, $A_{\text{wall}}/A_{\text{wafer}} = 11$, 28, 56 for AR 20, 50, 100.

2.3 Verification and validation

- Scaling tests on the feature solver: penetration depth $\sim \sqrt{\text{dose}}$; dose for 95 % step coverage $\sim \text{AR}^2$ in the diffusion-limited regime (ratio 4.0 for AR 20 $\rightarrow$ 40 at $s = 0.5$; drops to 3.2 at $s = 0.05$ where the front becomes reaction-limited); sticking coefficient recovered from a synthetic profile within 5 % (log).

- Two-code check: Machball [3] (ballistic, cosine re-emission) vs this Knudsen-continuum solver, 95 % bottom coverage time at 0.3 Pa TMA, 573 K: 1.20 vs 1.29 s (AR 20), 4.45 vs 4.46 s (AR 50), 16.2 vs 15.6 s (AR 100).

- Embedded-BC check: with negligible hole density the boundary condition's hole-bottom coverage matches the standalone solver driven by the same surface density to 1 % at all times.

- Validation against the Zenodo 3974438 PillarHall Al_2O_3 profiles [10, 9] (TMA/H_2O, 300 °C, 500 cycles $\times$ 0.1 s, 500 nm lateral channel, eight profiles averaged): the slit model with channel narrowing fits the saturation front to an rms of 0.038 of the plateau with $s_{\text{TMA}} = 8.5 \times 10^{-3}$ (profile-to-profile factor 1.5) and a mouth exposure of 7.5 Pa s per pulse (75 Pa TMA for 0.1 s), Fig. 1. The front position (AR 215 at half thickness) fixes the exposure; its width fixes s. Published values: 0.5–2$\times 10^{-3}$ [5] (275 °C set-point); our value is higher, with temperature, the site-density assumption and lumped-vs-explicit kinetics as candidate reasons; $s = 10^{-3}$ at the same exposure is visibly excluded by the data. The chamber runs use 5×10^{-3}; the patterned-wafer conclusions are supply-limited and insensitive to it.

2.4 Validation against a measured high-surface-area ALD run

A patterned wafer with tens of wafer-areas of holes is, to the chamber, a powder bed. The cleanest published measurement of supply-limited ALD is Argonne's fluidized-bed Al_2O_3 run on 940 m^2 of silica gel [12]: in-situ mass spectrometry put TMA breakthrough at 24 min, and the authors' own accounting gives 0.0115 ± 0.0020 mol of TMA supplied in that time against 0.0103 mol needed. In the normalisation used throughout this paper, saturation arrived at 1.12 (0.92 to 1.31) times the supply-limit time. Our twelve patterned-wafer cases, with nothing tuned to that experiment, saturate at 1.05 to 1.27 times theirs (Fig. 2); the blanket wafers, at a Damköhler number of 10 instead of hundreds, sit at 1.5 to 4.3 and are the kinetics-limited exception. Argonne's plug-flow theory [12, 13] predicts the same approach to unity from above. A second measured set, TMA utilization in a rotary-drum reactor at five silica-gel loadings from 40 to 1500 m^2 [14, Table 2], rises from 25 % to 71 % with area, i.e. saturation moves from 4.0 to 1.4 supply-limit times as the reactor fills with surface; our blanket and patterned wafers (0.07 to 4 m^2) and the fluidized bed (940 m^2, 92 %) fall on the same trend across five orders of magnitude of surface area (Fig. 2, right panel).

2.5 Chamber-scale checks

The blanket-wafer pulse of Section 3.1 can be compared with published saturation data once the exposure is defined with care. The recipe sets a feed exposure, 3 Pa of TMA for 0.345 s, 1.03 Pa s

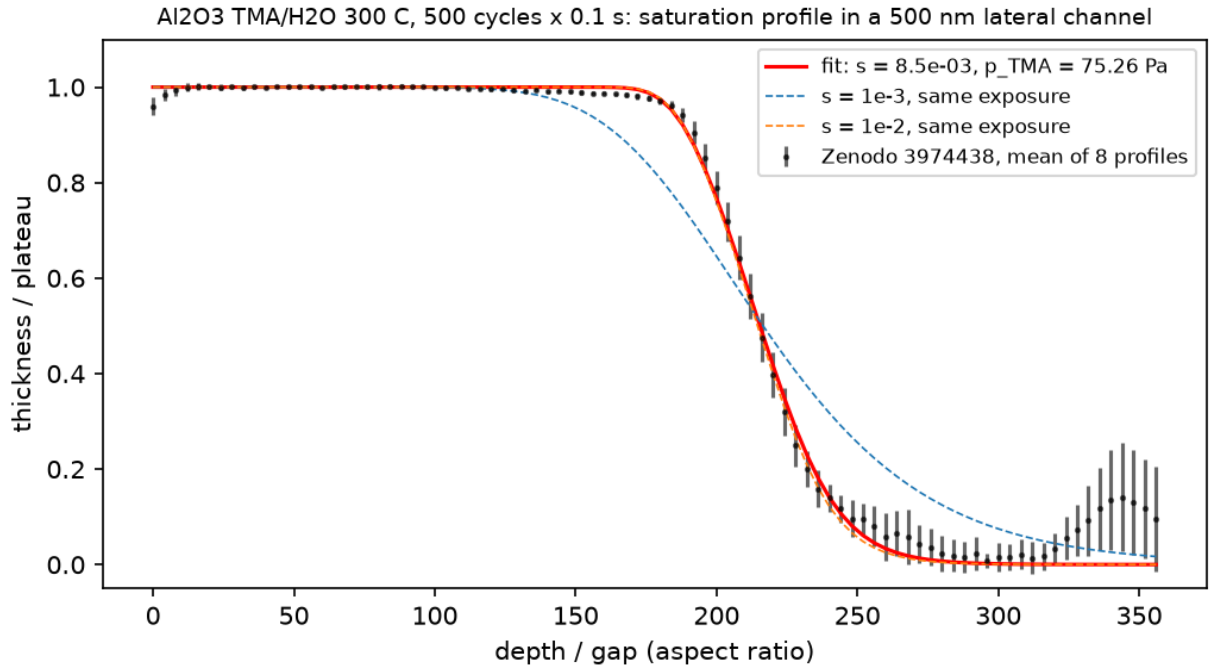


Figure 1: Validation of the feature model against the Zenodo 3974438 PillarHall data [10]: the mean of eight measured Al_2O_3 thickness profiles (TMA/H_2O, 300 °C, 500 cycles × 0.1 s) in a 500 nm lateral channel, normalised to the plateau thickness and plotted against depth expressed as aspect ratio. The red line is the two-parameter fit of the slit model with channel narrowing ($s_{\mathrm{TMA}} = 8.5 \times 10^{-3}$, 75 Pa TMA at the mouth); the dashed lines show $s = 10^{-3}$ and 10^{-2} at the same exposure.

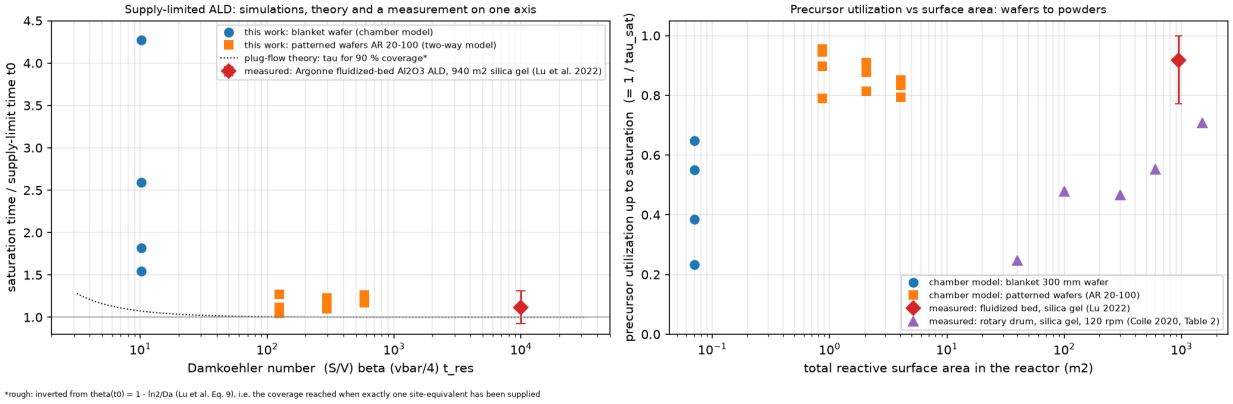


Figure 2: The supply-limit rule against measurements. Left: saturation time divided by the supply-limit time t_0 versus Damköhler number for the blanket and patterned chamber runs of this work, the plug-flow theory of Lu et al. [12], and the measured Argonne fluidized-bed Al_2O_3 run on 940 m^2 of silica gel. Right: precursor utilization up to saturation ($= 1/\tau_{\mathrm{sat}}$) versus total reactive surface area in the reactor, from a 0.07 m^2 blanket wafer to 1500 m^2 of powder, with the fluidized-bed point [12] and the rotary-drum loadings of Coile et al. [14].

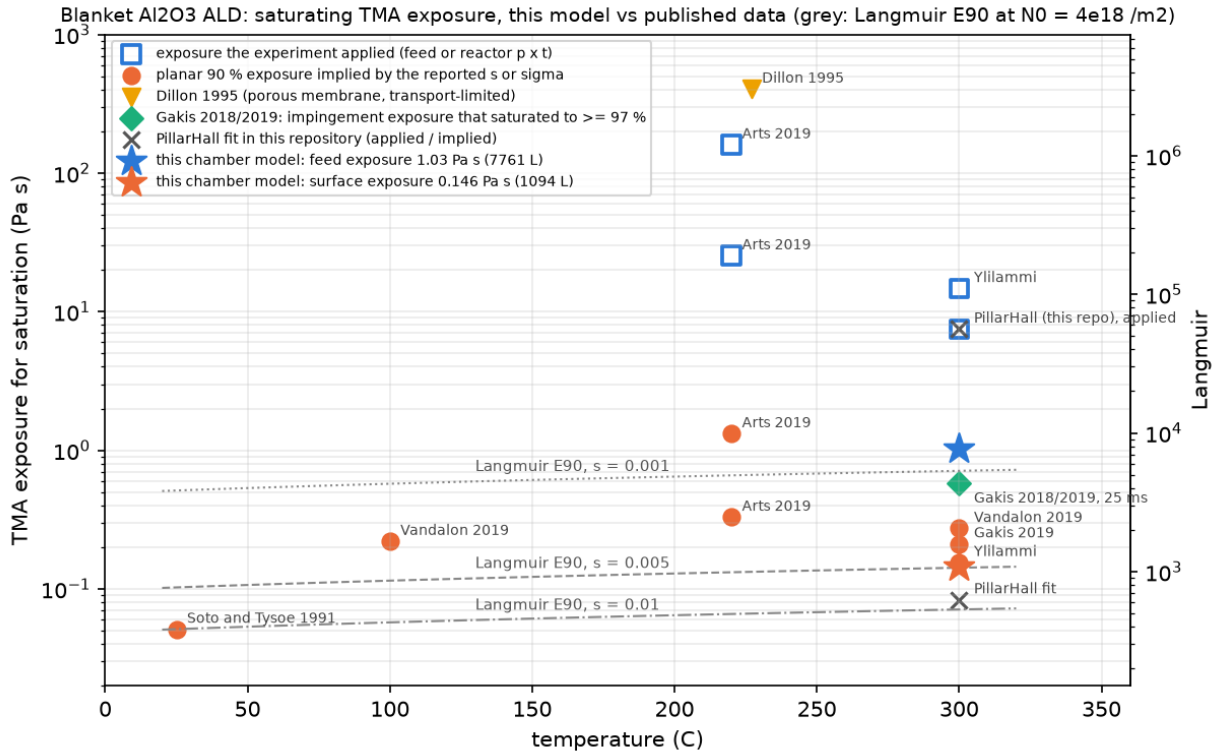


Figure 3: TMA exposure for saturation against temperature. Open squares: exposures the experiments applied (feed or reactor pressure times time); filled circles: planar 90 % exposure implied by each source's sticking coefficient or cross-section; diamond: the Gakis et al. 25 ms impingement exposure that gave at least 97 % saturation; crosses: the PillarHall fit of this work; stars: this chamber model, feed exposure (1.03 Pa s, 7,760 L) and surface exposure (0.146 Pa s, 1,090 L); grey lines: Langmuir E_{90} at $N_0 = 4 \times 10^{18}$ m^{-2} for $s = 10^{-3}$, 5×10^{-3} and 10^{-2}. Right axis in Langmuir.

or 7,800 Langmuir; the surface sees the time integral of its own TMA partial pressure, 0.146 Pa s or 1,100 Langmuir, because the wafer draws the gas down to 0.14 of the feed value on average while it saturates, and that surface exposure equals the Langmuir value $\ln(10)\, N_0/(sF_1)$ at $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$, as it must. Seven independent sources give either the exposure they applied or a sticking coefficient or reaction cross-section from which the planar saturating exposure follows (Fig. 3, Table 1). The kinetic values span 0.05 to 1.3 Pa s: 0.27 Pa s from the sum-frequency cross-section of Vandalon and Kessels [24, 23], 0.21 from the reactor-fitted sticking coefficient of Gakis et al. [21], 0.16 from the PillarHall fit of Ylilammi et al. [4], 0.33 to 1.3 from Arts et al. [5] at 220 °C, 0.05 at room temperature in vacuum (Soto and Tysoe [26], as summarised by Puurunen [25]), 0.08 from our own PillarHall fit. Our 0.146 Pa s sits in the middle of the 300 °C cluster, within a factor 1.8 of each of the three sources that state a sticking coefficient at that temperature; the applied exposures (0.56 to 160 Pa s) are upper bounds that recipes choose to over-dose and say nothing sharper. Exposure scales as $1/s$ in this regime, so the model would reproduce the individual sources at s between 2.7×10^{-3} and 8.7×10^{-3}.

A second check uses the one published case that combines reactor-scale CFD with a measured thickness map in a commercial tool: the Ultratech Fiji F200 of Gakis et al. [20, 21] (200 mm wafer, 9.6 Pa Ar, 180 sccm, 300 °C, 0.63 mg of TMA per 25 ms valve opening, measured growth per cycle

Table 1: Blanket saturation exposures: this chamber model against published data. "Applied" exposures are what the experiment delivered (feed or reactor pressure times time); "kinetic E_{90}" is the planar 90 % exposure implied by the source's sticking coefficient or cross-section. Values read from figures are noted in `figures/blanket_saturation_literature.csv`.

Source	T (°C)	Kind of exposure	Exposure (Pa s)	Langmuir	s this model would need
This work, chamber model, centre: feed $p \times t_{90}$	300	applied	1.03	7,760	5×10^{-3} (as run)
This work, centre: surface integral of $p_s\,dt$ to $\theta = 0.9$	300	kinetic	0.146	1,090	5×10^{-3} (as run)
Ylilammi et al. 2018 [4], Picosun R-150, 300 Pa, 0.1 s pulse: fitted entrance pressure 147 Pa × 0.1 s (flat region saturated)	300	applied	14.7	110,000	upper bound only
same, implied by their fitted $\gamma = 5.72 \times 10^{-3}$ ($q = 5 \times 10^{18}$ m^{-2})	300	kinetic E_{90}	0.155	1,160	4.7×10^{-3}
Arts et al. 2019 [5], Oxford OpAL, set-point 275 °C: 190 mTorr s TMA dose, planar surface saturated	∼220	applied	25.3	190,000	upper bound only
same, 1200 mTorr s (H_2O-limited profile)	∼220	applied	160	1,200,000	upper bound only
same, implied by $s_0 = 2 \times 10^{-3}$ / 5×10^{-4} (Table I range; $N_0 = 4 \times 10^{18}$ assumed)	∼220	kinetic E_{90}	0.33 / 1.32	2,470 / 9,890	2.2×10^{-3} / 5.5×10^{-4}
Vandalon and Kessels 2019 [24], SFG, $\sigma_{\mathrm{TMA}} = (6.5 \pm 0.6) \times 10^{-18}$ cm^2; temperature-independent 100–300 °C [23]	300 (100)	kinetic E_{90} from σ, no site density needed	0.273 (0.221)	2,050 (1,650)	2.7×10^{-3} (3.3×10^{-3})
Gakis et al. 2018 [20], Fiji F200, 9.6 Pa, 25 ms valve: wafer impingement 0.0118–0.0130 mol/m^2 (±0.0002) × 46.45 Pa s per mol/m^2; GPC 0.975–0.998 Å/cycle, i.e. ≥ 97 % saturated	300	applied (their CFD)	0.55–0.60	4,100–4,500	upper bound only
Gakis et al. 2019 [21], implied by fitted $s_0 = 0.004 \times 86$ % reaction probability, $N_0 = 4.1 \times 10^{18}$ from GPC 1.0 Å/cycle at 3500 kg/m^3	300	kinetic E_{90}	0.212	1,590	3.4×10^{-3}
PillarHall record (Zenodo 3974438 [10]), this work's fit: mouth exposure 75 Pa × 0.1 s	300	applied	7.5	56,000	upper bound only
same, implied by the fitted $s = 8.5 \times 10^{-3}$	300	kinetic E_{90}	0.084	630	8.7×10^{-3}
Soto and Tysoe 1991 [26], UHV, as summarised by Puurunen 2005 [25]: reaction probability 0.01	25	kinetic E_{90} ($N_0 = 4 \times 10^{18}$ assumed)	0.051	380	1.4×10^{-2}
Dillon et al. 1995 [27], porous alumina FTIR, as summarised by Puurunen 2005: $k_a = 0.0076\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$ at 0.01 Torr	227	first-order rate on a porous membrane: transport, not planar kinetics	404	3,000,000	(1.8×10^{-6}, not meaningful)

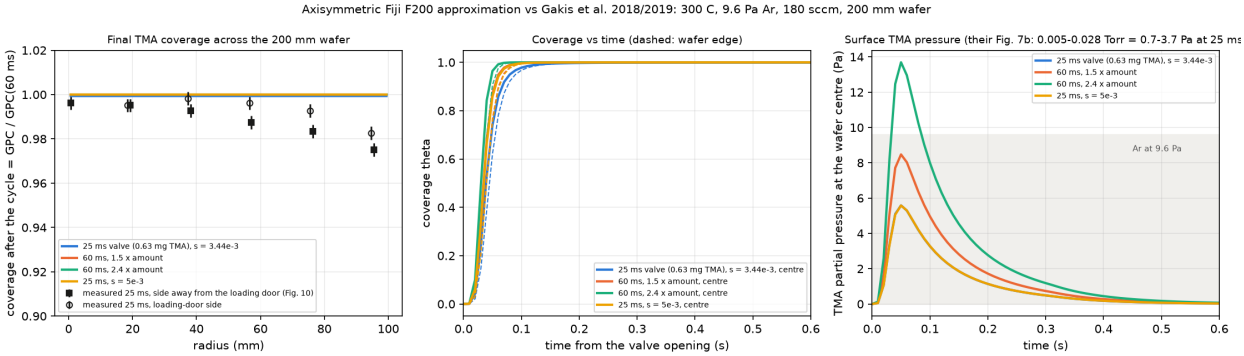


Figure 4: Axisymmetric approximation of the Fiji F200 against Gakis et al. [20, 21]. Left: coverage after the cycle across the 200 mm wafer for the four cases, with the measured 25 ms growth-per-cycle profile (their 2019 Fig. 10, digitised, divided by the 1.00 Å/cycle of the 60 ms pulse; filled squares the side away from the loading door, open circles the loading-door side, ±0.003). Middle: coverage against time at the centre (solid) and edge (dashed). Right: TMA partial pressure at the wafer centre; the shaded band is the 9.6 Pa of Ar.

0.975 to 0.998 Å/cycle along the diameter against 1.00 at 60 ms, non-uniformity 2.4 % falling to 0.58 %). We rebuilt the chamber as an axisymmetric wedge with dimensions read off their cross-section (the papers give none), a single axial inlet standing in for their three, the carrier flow frozen, their computed pulse amount and shape, and their kinetic model reduced to an irreversible sticking coefficient $s = 0.004 \times 0.86 = 3.4 \times 10^{-3}$ and $N_0 = 4.1 \times 10^{18}\,\mathrm{m}^{-2}$ from their growth per cycle (Fig. 4, Table 2). The model delivers 0.67 Pa s of TMA impingement to the wafer against 0.55 to 0.60 Pa s in their three-dimensional CFD and saturates the wafer with the 25 ms pulse (coverage 0.9994, 90 % at 70 ms) and completely with the 60 ms pulse, as the measurement does to within 2.5 %. It does not reproduce the 2.4 % non-uniformity: their exposure field is 10.7 % non-uniform because the pulse momentum through an off-axis inlet drives a recirculation over the wafer and the loading-door purge sweeps one side, ours is 0.3 % because an axisymmetric inlet into a diffusive gap smooths everything; and with irreversible Langmuir kinetics even their exposure variation would move coverage by under 0.5 %, so the remainder is their reversible, softer kinetics and the 21 °C temperature gradient and cold loading door they document. The chamber-scale transport that this paper's conclusions rest on, how much of the injected precursor the wafer takes before the pump does, is reproduced to the accuracy of the dimensions; the within-wafer uniformity of a particular injector is not a claim of this paper.

3 Results

3.1 Blanket wafer

Fixed-concentration inlet absorbs 1179 % of the injected TMA; total-flux inlet 96.5 %. Centre flux plateaus at the supply rate Uc_0: at Pe = 0.09 the chamber is supply-limited. Dose uniform to 1 % out to $r = 100$ mm, 7 % dip at $r = 142$ mm (radial sweep), edge spike from the un-patterned floor ring. Gas phase clears 0.05 s after the pulse. Sticking sweep: capture 96 → 65 %, within-wafer spread 7 → 0.2 %, purge tail 0.15 → 0.58 s for $s = 1 \to 10^{-3}$. Self-limiting wafer, $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$, 1 % TMA: 90 % coverage at 0.35 s (centre), 0.38 s (edge). Operating sweep: pulse time follows the supply time $N_0/(Uc_0)$ at 1.6 to 2.3×; pressure does not change it at fixed sccm but raises the edge

Table 2: Fiji F200 reproduction against Gakis et al. [20, 21]: coverage after the cycle over $|r| \leq 95\,\mathrm{mm}$, within-wafer non-uniformity $(\max - \min)/\min$, time to 90 % after valve opening, TMA impingement exposure on the wafer, TMA captured by the wafer, and peak surface TMA partial pressure.

Case	θ after the cycle, centre / min / max	Non-uniformity	t_{90} centre / worst	Wafer exposure (Pa s)	Exposure non-uniformity	TMA captured	Peak surface TMA (Pa)
25 ms valve, 0.63 mg, $s = 3.44 \times 10^{-3}$	0.9994 / 0.9994 / 0.9994	0.0007 %	0.07 / 0.08 s	0.671–0.673	0.28 %	2.4 % of 5.26×10^{18} (41 monolayer-equivalents delivered)	5.6
60 ms, 1.5× amount	1.0000 / 1.0000 / 1.0000	0.00001 %	0.06 / 0.06 s	1.017–1.019	0.18 %	1.6 %	8.5
60 ms, 2.4× amount	1.0000 / 1.0000 / 1.0000	0.0000 %	0.05 / 0.05 s	1.639–1.640	0.11 %	1.0 %	13.7
25 ms, $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$	1.0000 / 1.0000 / 1.0000	0.00003 %	0.06 / 0.07 s	0.671–0.673	0.28 %	2.4 %	5.6
Measured, 25 ms (2019 Fig. 10, digitised, / 1.00 Å per cycle at 60 ms)	0.996 / 0.975 / 0.998	2.37 % (2.40 % stated)					
Measured, 60 ms (stated)	1.00	0.58 %					
Their CFD + kinetics, 25 / 60 ms		2.45 % / 0.83 %		0.55–0.60 (2018 Fig. 12)	10.7 %		0.7–3.7 at 25 ms (2019 Fig. 7b)

lag from 5 % (100 Pa) to 14 % (1000 Pa); a 10 mm gap beats 25 mm on time and uniformity.

3.2 One-way coupling and the shielding effect

Driving a 100 nm hole with the blanket wafer's surface density: AR 50 bottom saturates at 0.92 s, against 4.45 s at constant density, because the flat surface stops consuming TMA at 0.35 s and the surface density rises tenfold. AR 100: 3 % coverage at the bottom after a 1 s pulse. Radius shifts the AR 50 time by only 10 %.

3.3 Two-way coupling: loading

3D-NAND-like wafer, AR 100, 1 % TMA: surface density collapses to $0.019\,c_0$ ($0.24\,c_0$ blanket), the wafer captures 94 % of the injected TMA during a 1 s pulse, and nothing saturates; a 1 s pulse delivers 8 % of the demand. Long pulses (Fig. 5): hole bottoms reach 90 % at 14.05 s (centre), 13.3 s (edge); flat regions between holes at 1.95 s (0.35 s blanket). 3 % TMA: 4.75 s.

3.4 The pulse-time map and the design rule

Table 3 gives the saturating pulse at the worst point on the wafer, and Fig. 6 plots it. Patterned wafers sit at 1.05 to 1.25× the supply limit $(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}})\, N_0/(U c_0)$ over the whole map; blanket wafers at 1.4 to 3.5× their own limit, rising with feed fraction as kinetics takes over. Design rule:

$$t_{\mathrm{pulse}} \approx 1.2\left(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}}\right) \frac{N_0}{U c_0}. \tag{4}$$

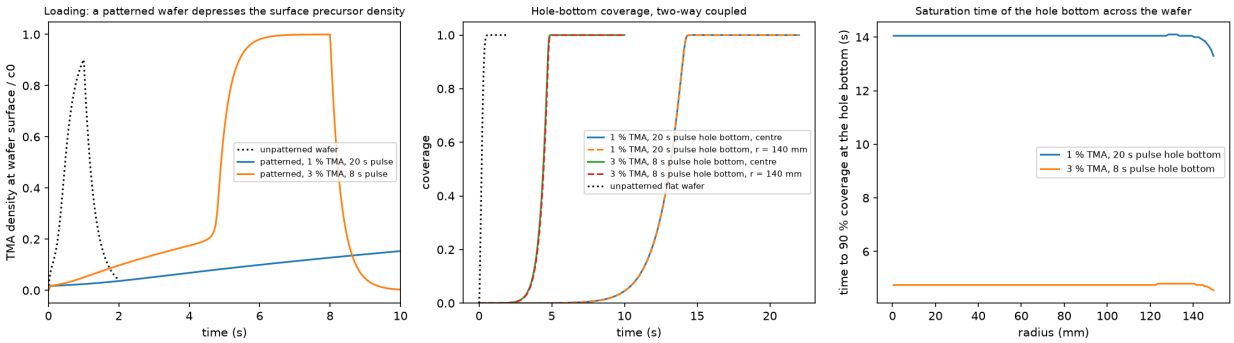


Figure 5: Two-way coupling on the 3D-NAND-like AR-100 wafer, 1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 20 s pulse. Left: TMA density at the wafer surface relative to c_0 for the unpatterned and the patterned wafer, showing the loading effect. Centre: hole-bottom coverage versus time at the wafer centre and at $r = 140$ mm, with the unpatterned flat wafer for comparison. Right: time to 90 % coverage at the hole bottom across the wafer radius.

Table 3: Pulse time to 90 % coverage at the worst point on the wafer, from sixteen two-way multiscale runs in the baseline chamber (300 Pa, 300 sccm, 15 mm gap; $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$, $N_0 = 4 \times 10^{18}$ m^{-2}). Patterned wafers carry 100 nm holes at AR 20, 50 and 100, i.e. wall area 11, 28 and 56 times the wafer area.

TMA fraction	Blanket (s)	AR 20 bottoms (s)	AR 50 bottoms (s)	AR 100 bottoms (s)
0.5 %	0.65	5.37	13.4	28.1
1 %	0.38	2.71	6.73	14.1
3 %	0.18	0.95	2.32	4.79
10 %	0.09	0.33	0.75	1.51

3.5 H_2O half-cycle

Blanket: 1.74 s (5× TMA; $s\bar{v}/4 = 0.02$ m/s $< U$). Patterned AR 100: 13.4 s (TMA 14.05 s), flat-to-bottom lag 2.6 s against 12 s for TMA. Cycle time ∼30 s at 1 % precursors vs ∼2.5 s blanket. The effect of reversible water adsorption on coverage and on the purge tail is shown in Fig. 7 and discussed in Section 4.

3.6 Temporal versus spatial ALD

The design rule gives the molecules required per unit wafer area per half-cycle,

$$\Phi_{\mathrm{req}} = 1.2\left(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}}\right) N_0. \tag{5}$$

A temporal showerhead tool delivers them at Uc_0 over the whole wafer and pays two purges per cycle; a separated-chemistry (spatial) tool delivers them in passes through a precursor zone at a flux k times the showerhead flux and pays rotation time instead of purges. With $k = 30$, a 1 s rotation and a 25 % zone, the two architectures tie on blanket wafers (2 s per cycle) and diverge linearly with patterned area: 6.8 vs 2 s at $A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}} = 11$ (AR 20), 29.9 vs 4 s at 56 (AR 100), 55.9 vs 8 s at 112. The crossover lies at $A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}}$ of 5 to 10 for $k = 30$; k is the one quantity a

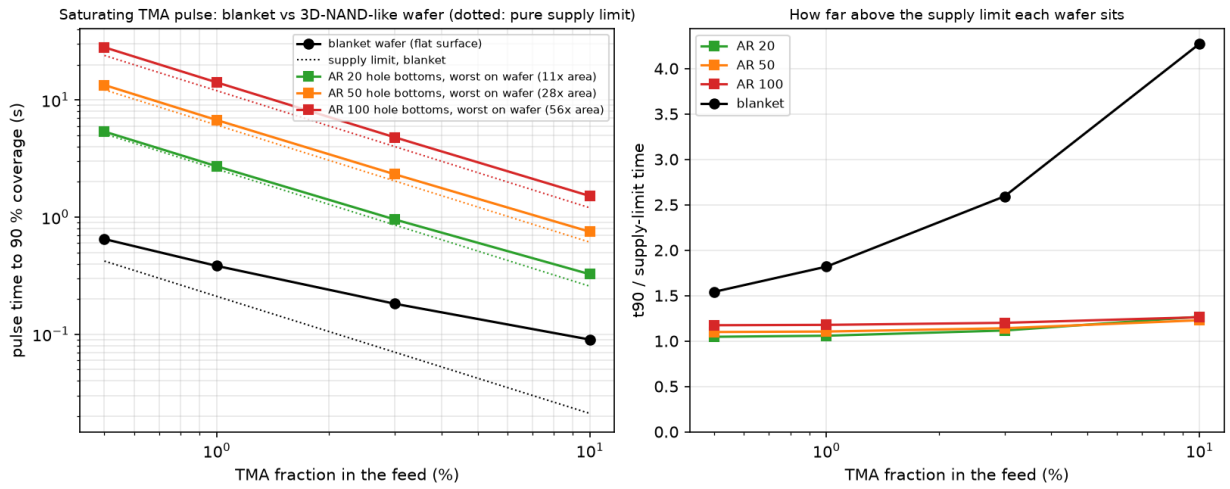


Figure 6: The pulse-time map. Left: saturating TMA pulse (time to 90 % coverage at the worst point on the wafer) versus TMA fraction in the feed for the blanket wafer and for 3D-NAND-like wafers with AR 20, 50 and 100 hole bottoms; the dotted line is the pure supply limit for the blanket wafer. Right: the same times divided by each wafer's own supply-limit time, showing the patterned wafers at 1.05–1.25 and the blanket wafer at 1.4–3.5.

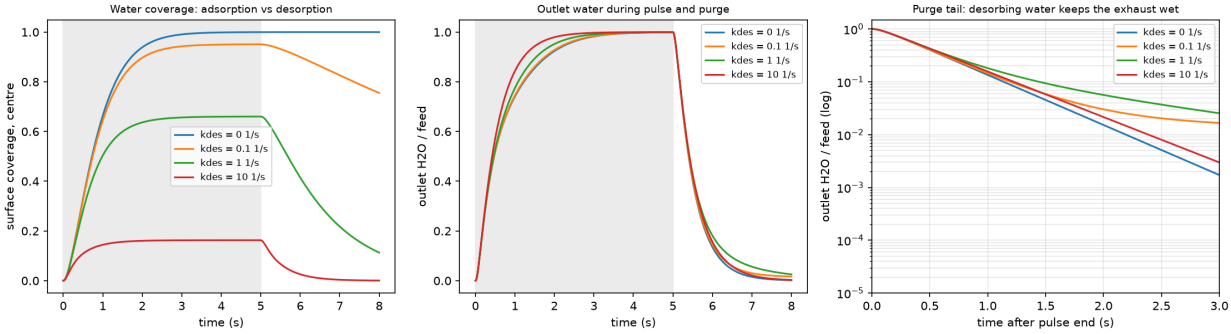


Figure 7: Reversible water adsorption on the blanket wafer, 1 % H_2O, 5 s pulse followed by a 3 s purge, for first-order desorption rates k_{des} = 0, 0.1, 1 and 10 s^{-1}. Left: surface coverage at the wafer centre. Centre: outlet H_2O relative to the feed during pulse and purge. Right: the purge tail on a logarithmic scale; desorbing water keeps the exhaust above 1 % of the pulse level for seconds at $k_{des} = 0.1$ to 1 s^{-1}.

tool maker knows and we do not, so Fig. 8 is a design chart in k. This is the quantitative form of the argument behind separated-chemistry ALD architectures for 3D NAND [16, 18].

3.7 Plasma ALD: the recombination ceiling

With a wall loss probability r for radicals, the time to 90 % bottom coverage in a 100 nm AR-100 hole rises from 8.0 s ($r = 0$) to 8.6 s (3×10^{-5}), 10.2 s (10^{-4}), 16 s (3×10^{-4}) and 64 s (10^{-3}), and the bottom is not reached at $r \geq 3\times10^{-3}$; the largest aspect ratio saturating within a 5 s exposure falls from 79 ($r = 10^{-5}$) to 56 (10^{-3}) and 29 (10^{-2}), Fig. 9. For O atoms on SiO_2 and TiO_2 ($r \sim 6\times10^{-5}$ [6, 7]) recombination is a 10 to 25 % penalty at AR 100; on high-recombination surfaces it is a hard

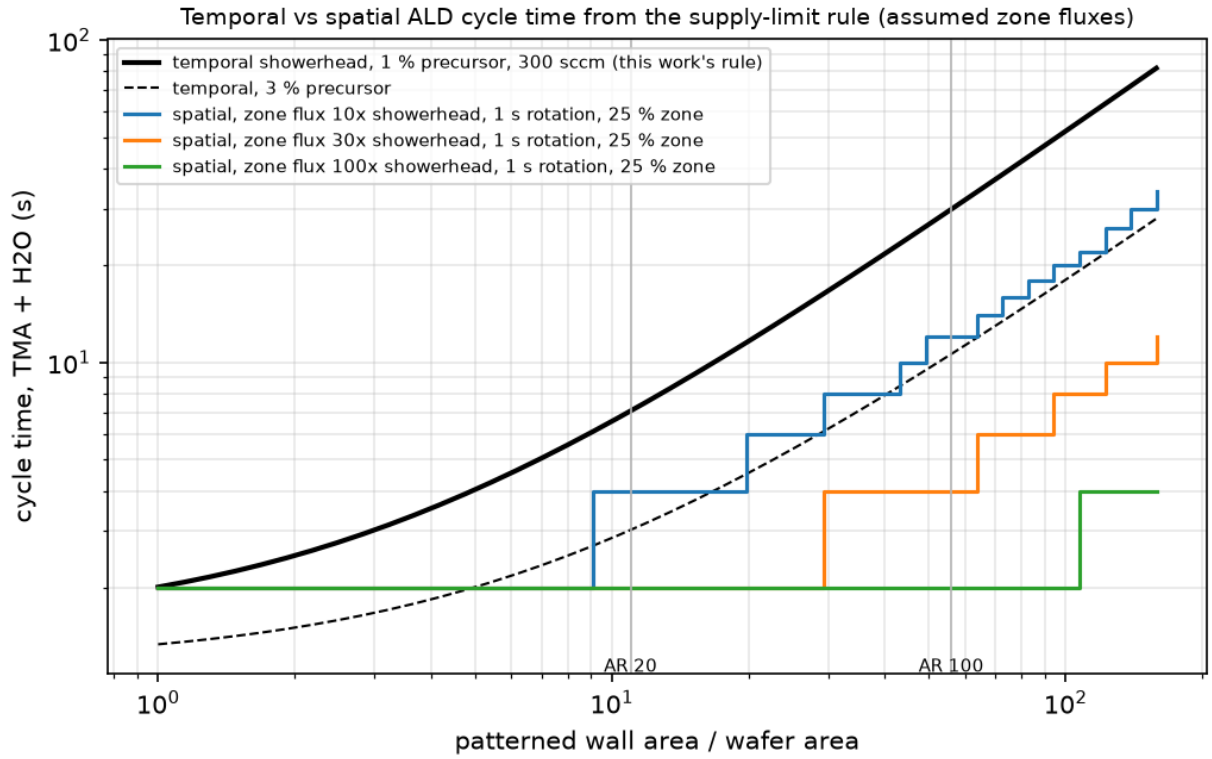


Figure 8: Temporal versus spatial ALD cycle time (TMA + H_2O) from the supply-limit rule, as a function of patterned wall area over wafer area. Solid and dashed black: temporal showerhead tool at 1 % and 3 % precursor, 300 sccm, with two purges per cycle. Steps: separated-chemistry (spatial) tool with a precursor-zone flux of 10, 30 and 100 times the showerhead flux, 1 s rotation and a 25 % zone; the zone fluxes are assumed, so the figure is a design chart in k. Vertical lines mark AR 20 and AR 100 of the 3D-NAND-like wafer.

ceiling that no pulse length removes, and radical flux (plasma source design) or surface chemistry become the levers. The radical sticking coefficient (0.05) is assumed.

3.8 Operating optimum and uncertainty

A face-centred central composite design (25 two-way runs; TMA fraction 0.5–3 %, carrier 150–600 sccm, pressure 100–1000 Pa, gap 10–25 mm) on the AR-100 wafer, fitted as a response surface in JMP and as a Gaussian-process surrogate in MATLAB and scikit-learn (leave-one-out R^2 0.999 for log pulse time, 0.988 for utilization), gives the second-order corrections to the rule (Fig. 10). Pulse time scales as $x^{-1.0}$, $Q^{-0.8}$ and $p^{-0.12}$; the gap is not significant. Precursor utilization up to saturation rises from 68 % at 100 Pa to 88 % at 1000 Pa and falls from 88 % at 150 sccm to 68 % at 600 sccm: carrier gas that is not needed to deliver precursor carries it past the wafer. The fastest point with edge lag under 5 % (a constraint never active: lag stays within −3.5 to +1.1 %) is 3 %, 600 sccm, 1000 Pa, 10 mm at 2.38 s. At fixed precursor flow, trading carrier gas for pressure (2.5 %, 150 sccm, 630 Pa, 10 mm) cuts the pulse from 11.6 to 9.8 s and raises utilization from 85 to 94 %. A Monte Carlo over the site density (lognormal, factor 1.25) puts a 90 % band of 8.2 to 17.2 s on the 11.9 s rule prediction at the design centre; the absolute pulse inherits the site-density uncertainty,

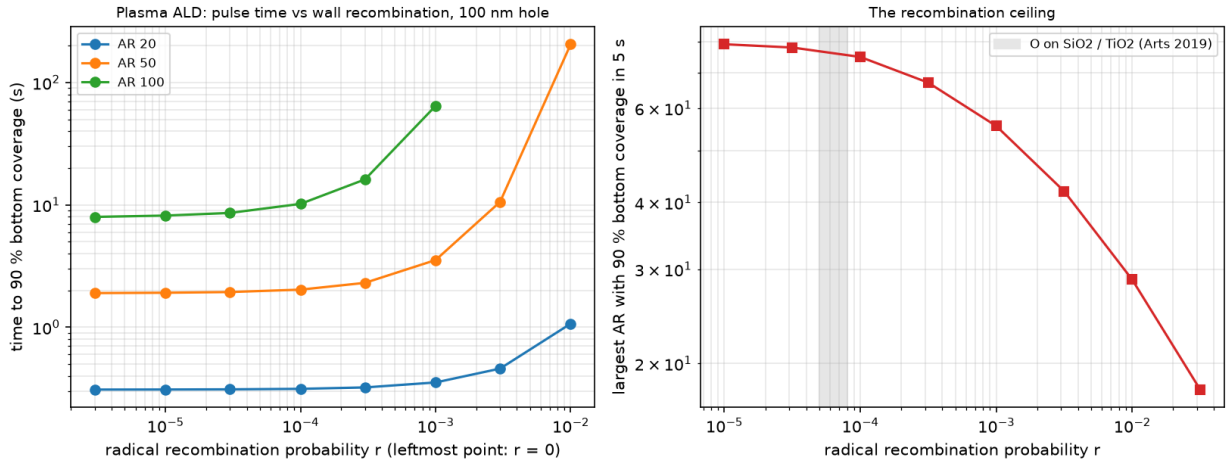


Figure 9: Plasma ALD in a 100 nm hole with radical sticking coefficient 0.05. Left: time to 90 % bottom coverage versus the radical recombination probability r on the hole walls for AR 20, 50 and 100 (leftmost point: $r = 0$). Right: the largest aspect ratio whose bottom reaches 90 % coverage within a 5 s exposure, versus r; the shaded band marks the measured range for O atoms on SiO_2 and TiO_2 [6].

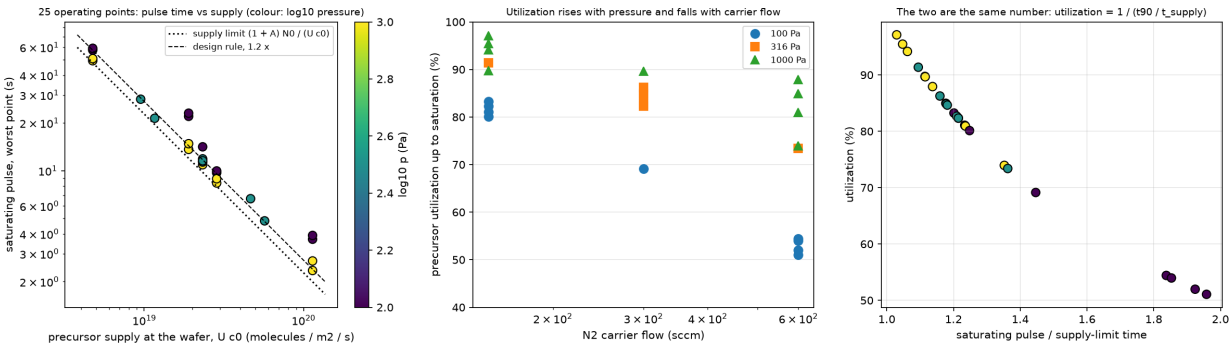


Figure 10: The 25-run central composite design on the AR-100 wafer. Left: saturating pulse at the worst point on the wafer versus precursor supply at the wafer Uc_0, coloured by $\log_{10}$ pressure, with the supply limit $(1 + A_{\text{wall}}/A_{\text{wafer}})\, N_0/(Uc_0)$ (dotted) and the 1.2× design rule (dashed). Centre: precursor utilization up to saturation versus N_2 carrier flow at 100, 316 and 1000 Pa. Right: utilization against the ratio of saturating pulse to supply-limit time, which are the same number.

the ratios in this paper do not. The scikit-learn GP reproduces the MATLAB leave-one-out R^2: 0.999 / 0.746 / 0.986 against 0.999 / 0.780 / 0.988 for time / edge lag / utilization. The cost-of-ownership front of pulse time against TMA per saturating pulse, over the factor ranges with edge lag under 5 % (Fig. 11): at the centre point's pulse time (11.6 s) the front uses 1.044 times the stoichiometric minimum of TMA against 1.181 at the centre, a 12 % saving per wafer pass at no cost in time; the last 1 % of saving (to 1.030 at 48.9 s) costs 4.2 times the pulse time.

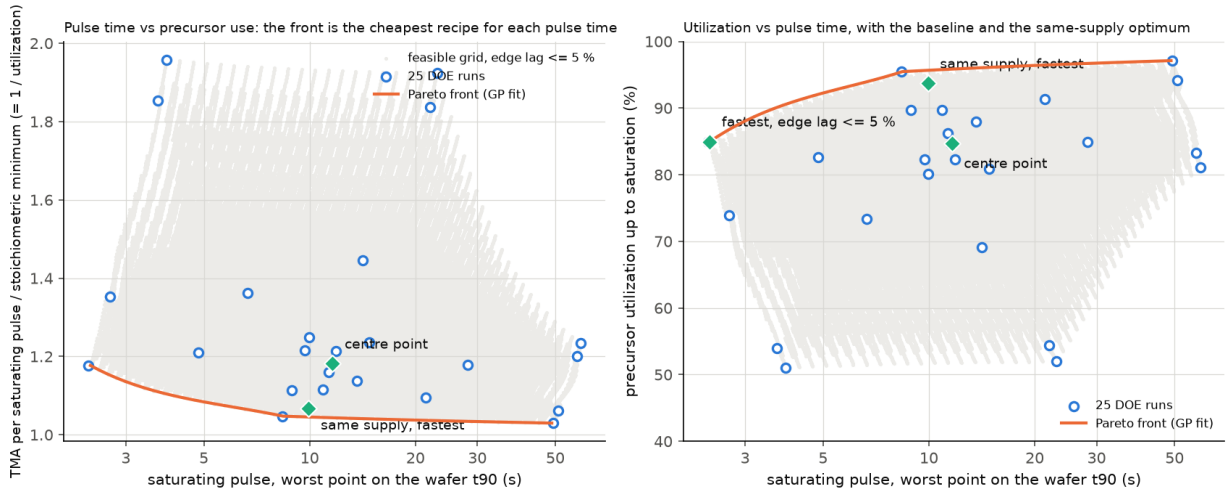


Figure 11: Cost-of-ownership front from the scikit-learn GP surrogate over the DOE factor ranges, restricted to points with edge lag $\leq 5\,\%$. Left: TMA delivered per saturating pulse relative to the stoichiometric minimum ($= 1/\text{utilization}$) versus the saturating pulse at the worst point on the wafer, with the 25 DOE runs, the centre point, the fastest feasible point and the fastest point at the centre's precursor supply. Right: the same front as precursor utilization versus pulse time.

3.9 Non-uniform layouts: the local wall-area ratio sets the pulse

The patterned-surface boundary condition takes hole density and aspect ratio as functions of radius (`ARProfile` and `holeDensityProfile` tables, interpolated at each face; a face with zero hole density is a flat Langmuir surface); the uniform case rerun with the rebuilt library is identical to the original to the 8 written digits at every face and write time. Two layouts at 1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 300 Pa (Fig. 12): (a) a dense AR-100 centre, full hole density for $r < 75$ mm ramping to bare wafer at 100 mm, wafer-average wall-area ratio 19.2; (b) full density everywhere with AR 100 at the centre ramping to 60 at the edge, wafer-average ratio 41.0. The rule with the wafer-average ratio underpredicts both: 5.1 s against the 11.85 s the dense centre needs, 10.6 s against 12.5 s for the AR ramp. With the local ratio of the most demanding region (55.9 at the centre of both) it predicts 14.4 s and is conservative by 15 to 21 %, against 2 % on the uniform wafer; the surplus is what the less-demanding neighbourhood feeds back laterally. A pattern boundary produces a saturation gradient inside the array: 11.85 s at the centre and 8.75 s at $r = 74.5$ mm, the last face at full density, a 26 % gradient where the uniform wafer varies by 0.4 %. The bare edge of layout (a) saturates 15 to 30 % slower than a blanket wafer (flat t_{90} 0.40 to 0.50 s against 0.35 to 0.38 s) because the array draws down the gas: surface TMA $0.163\,c_0$ over the bare region at 0.3 s against $0.24\,c_0$ on a blanket wafer. On the AR ramp the bottom time tracks the local aspect ratio (12.5 s at AR 100 to 7.6 s at AR 60) while the flat regions are unaffected (1.95 s): a 40 % depth variation gives a 39 % spread in saturation time, so the recipe is set by the deepest tier and shallower regions are over-dosed by their depth ratio.

3.10 Step coverage, purge and throughput

In fab units the rule reads as follows. Step coverage, the hole-bottom coverage over the flat top, follows the supply integral: at 1 % TMA the bottoms of AR 20, 50 and 100 holes reach 90 % at 2.7, 6.7 and 14.1 s (worst face), 95 % at 2.8, 6.8 and 14.2 s and 99 % at 2.9, 7.0 and 14.3 s (Fig. 13,

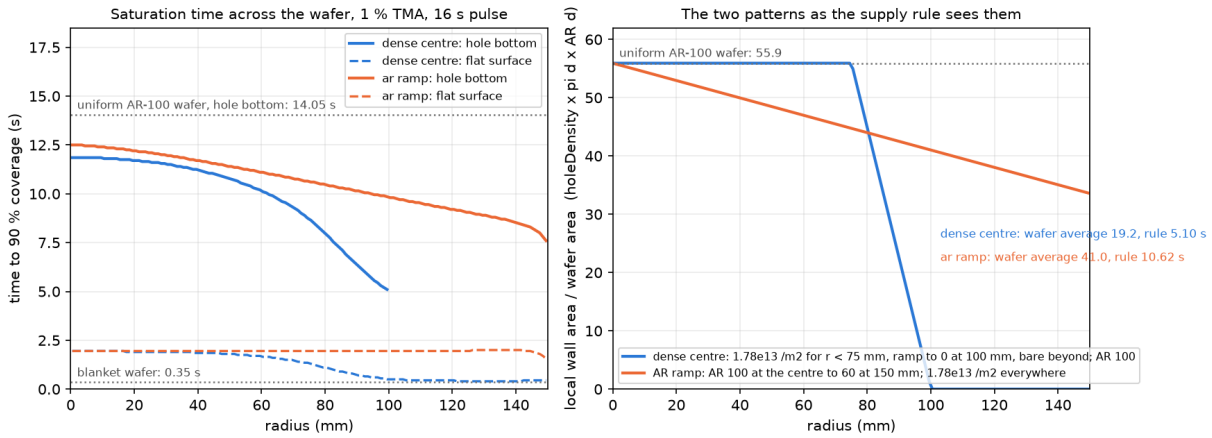


Figure 12: Two non-uniform layouts at 1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 300 Pa, 16 s pulse. Left: time to 90 % coverage at the hole bottom (solid) and on the flat surface (dashed) across the wafer for the dense-centre layout (AR 100, full hole density for $r < 75$ mm ramping to bare wafer at 100 mm) and the AR-ramp layout (full density, AR 100 at the centre to 60 at the edge), with the uniform AR-100 wafer (14.05 s) and the blanket wafer (0.35 s) as dotted references. Right: the local wall-area ratio of each layout versus radius, with the wafer averages (19.2 and 41.0) and the pulse the rule predicts from them (5.10 and 10.62 s).

Table 4: Pulse for 90, 95 and 99 % bottom coverage at 1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 300 Pa, 15 mm gap (step coverage $= \theta_{\text{bottom}}/\theta_{\text{flat}}$); "map" rows are the pulse-time-map runs, the last row the 20 s AR-100 run with 0.05 s writes. The rule is $1.2\,(1 + A_{\text{wall}}/A_{\text{wafer}})\,N_0/(Uc_0)$.

Wafer (run)	$A_{\text{wall}}/A_{\text{wafer}}$	Rule (s)	t_{90} centre / worst (s)	t_{95} centre / worst (s)	t_{99} centre / worst (s)	Flat top t_{90} / t_{95} / t_{99} (s)	t_{99} / rule
AR 20 (map, 4.61 s pulse)	11.2	3.08	2.67 / 2.71	2.78 / 2.81	2.92 / 2.94	1.84 / 2.14 / 2.60	0.96
AR 50 (map, 10.26 s)	28.0	7.32	6.73 / 6.73	6.83 / 6.83	6.94 / 6.99	1.94 / 2.35 / 3.06	0.95
AR 100 (map, 19.68 s)	55.9	14.38	14.01 / 14.11	14.21 / 14.21	14.31 / 14.31	1.96 / 2.35 / 3.04	1.00
AR 100 (20 s run)	55.9	14.38	14.05 / 14.10	14.15 / 14.20	14.25 / 14.30	1.95 / 2.30 / 3.05	0.99

Table 4). The front is sharp, $t_{99} - t_{90}$ is 0.25 to 0.3 s at every aspect ratio, so the rule's pulse (3.1, 7.3, 14.4 s) covers 99 % step coverage as well as 90 % (t_{99}/rule 0.95 to 1.00). The flat top between the holes saturates at 1.8 to 2.0 s regardless of aspect ratio. Converted to film at 0.103 nm per cycle (the PillarHall record's 51.5 nm after 500 cycles; the review value is about 0.1 nm per cycle [25]), 50 cycles of the blanket recipe (0.345 s) leave 1.4 nm of a 5.15 nm target on the top of an AR-100 array and nothing at the bottom, and a 20 % step coverage on an AR-20 array; 50 cycles of the rule's pulse leave 5.15 nm top and bottom on all three (Table 5).

The purge has three parts and only one of them is set by the chamber (Table 6). The hole itself empties by Knudsen diffusion in microseconds: for 100 nm × 10 μm and TMA at 573 K, $D_K = 1.4 \times 10^{-5}$ m^2/s, $L^2/D_K = 7\,\mu$s, and a transient solution with the mouth density set to zero puts the bottom density at 1 % after 14 μs. The chamber outlet signal falls with a time constant of 0.36 to 0.39 s for TMA and 0.46 s for water, between the gap transit (0.3 s) and the chamber

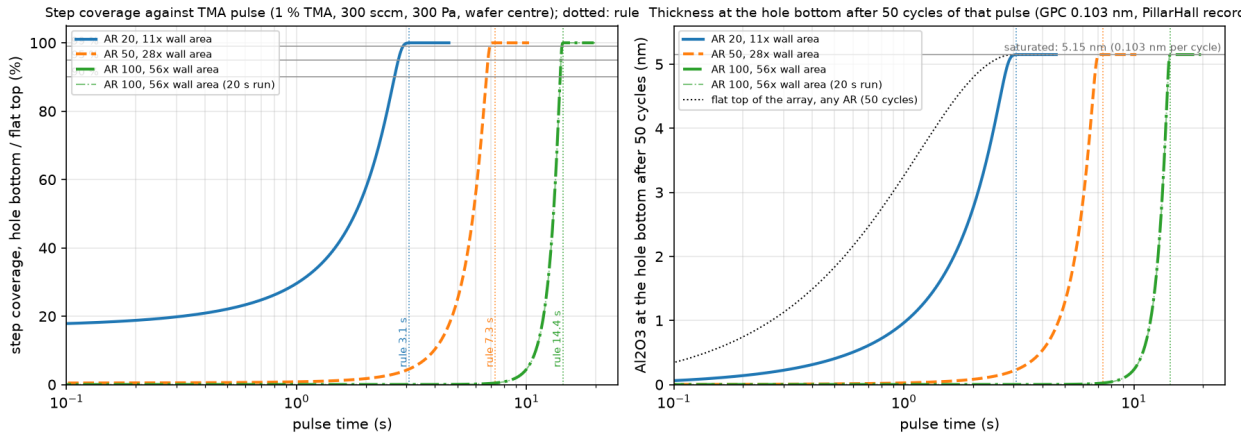


Figure 13: Left: step coverage (hole bottom over flat top, wafer centre) against pulse time for AR 20, 50 and 100 at 1 % TMA, with the 90, 95 and 99 % levels and the rule's pulse for each aspect ratio as dotted verticals (3.1, 7.3, 14.4 s); the 20 s AR-100 run is overlaid as the thin line. Right: Al_2O_3 thickness at the hole bottom after 50 cycles of that pulse (0.103 nm per cycle), with the flat top of the array as the dotted black line and the saturated 5.15 nm marked.

Table 5: Al_2O_3 after 50 cycles of a given pulse (0.103 nm per cycle; saturated film 5.15 nm), wafer centre: step coverage and bottom / top thickness.

Pulse	AR 20	AR 50	AR 100
0.345 s (blanket t_{90})	20 %, 0.26 / 1.29 nm	0.5 %, 0.01 / 1.32 nm	0 %, 0.00 / 1.44 nm
1 s	29 %, 0.95 / 3.23 nm	0.8 %, 0.03 / 3.25 nm	0 %, 0.00 / 3.16 nm
2 s	58 %, 2.76 / 4.79 nm	1.7 %, 0.08 / 4.69 nm	0 %, 0.00 / 4.67 nm
5 s	100 %, 5.15 / 5.15 nm	25 %, 1.27 / 5.15 nm	0.1 %, 0.00 / 5.15 nm
10 s	100 %, 5.15 / 5.15 nm	100 %, 5.15 / 5.15 nm	4.5 %, 0.23 / 5.15 nm
Rule (3.08 / 7.32 / 14.38 s)	100 %	100 %	100 %

volume over the flow (0.53 s): a decade costs about 1 s, 1 % of the pulse-end level takes 1.9 s (TMA) and 2.2 s (water), 0.1 % about 2.7 and 3.2 s. Desorbing water is the long part: at $k_{des} = 0.1\,s^{-1}$ the exhaust is held at 1.6 % of the feed level by the surface 3 s after the pulse and reaches 1 % only after about 8 s; at $1\,s^{-1}$, 4.3 s; at $10\,s^{-1}$ the surface empties within 0.3 s and the purge is gas clearing again (2.4 s). k_{des} is a parameter, not a measurement, and the water purge in the cycle below is the $k_{des} = 0.1\,s^{-1}$ value by choice.

The full Al_2O_3 cycle, TMA pulse, purge to 1 %, water pulse, purge [28], is 12.2 s on the blanket wafer (0.35 + 1.9 + 1.7 + 8.3 s), 37.6 s on the AR-100 wafer (14.05 + 1.9 + 13.4 + 8.3 s) and 29.4 s at the same-supply optimum of Section 3.8 (9.8 + 1.9 + 9.4 + 8.3 s, the water pulse scaled by the TMA ratio since the water half-cycle was not in the design, and the purges held at the baseline values; the optimum's lower carrier flow raises the chamber residence time 2.8-fold, so its TMA purge would scale to about 5 s and its cycle to about 33 s, a scaling estimate rather than a run). At 0.103 nm per cycle, 5 nm is 49 cycles: 10 min per wafer and 5.5 wafers per hour with 60 s of handling on the blanket wafer, 31 min and 1.9 wafers per hour on the AR-100 wafer, 24 min and 2.4 at the optimum; 10 nm doubles the minutes (Fig. 14, Table 7). With gas clearing only for water ($k_{des} = 0$,

Table 6: Purge times. (a) The hole, 100 nm × 10 μm, TMA at 573 K ($\bar{v} = 410$ m/s, $D_K = d\bar{v}/3 = 1.37 \times 10^{-5}$ m^2/s), walls saturated, mouth density zero. (b) Chamber outlet signal after the pulse ends, as a fraction of the pulse-end outlet value; "extr." = extrapolated with the exponential tail fitted over the last 40 % of the written purge window. (c) Reversible water on the blanket wafer, 5 s pulse at 1 %, outlet to 1 % of the pulse-end value.

(a)

Quantity	Value
L^2/D_K	7.3 μs
Slowest eigenmode $4L^2/(\pi^2 D_K)$ (Dirichlet mouth, Neumann bottom)	3.0 μs
Bottom density to 1 %, first mode $(4/\pi)\exp(-t/\tau_1)$	14.4 μs
Numeric: bottom density to $1/e$	3.7 μs
Numeric: bottom density to 1 %	14.4 μs
Numeric: hole-mean density to 1 %	13.1 μs

(b)

Run	Pulse	Outlet at pulse end	To 10 %	To 1 %	To 0.1 %	Tail decay rate (time constant)
TMA, patterned AR 100, 20 s pulse, purge to 22 s	20 s	1.000 c_0	1.10 s	1.90 s	2.73 s (extr.)	2.75 s^{-1} (0.36 s)
TMA, blanket, 0.5 s pulse, purge to 1.5 s	0.5 s	0.297 c_0 (peak 0.367 at +0.11 s)	1.25 s (extr.)	2.14 s (extr.)	3.04 s (extr.)	2.57 s^{-1} (0.39 s)
TMA, blanket, 1.26 s pulse, purge to 2.26 s (map)	1.26 s	0.888 c_0	1.07 s (extr.)	1.95 s (extr.)	2.83 s (extr.)	2.63 s^{-1} (0.38 s)
H_2O, blanket, $k_{des} = 0$, 5 s pulse, purge to 8 s	5 s	0.999 c_0	1.14 s	2.20 s	3.25 s (extr.)	2.18 s^{-1} (0.46 s)
Reference: gap transit 0.015 m / 0.050 m/s				0.30 s		
Reference: chamber volume / flow, $\pi\,0.2^2 \times 0.015$ m^3 / 3.54×10^{-3} m^3/s				0.53 s		

(c)

k_{des} (s^{-1})	Coverage at pulse end / 3 s after	Outlet 3 s after the pulse	Purge to 1 %	Basis
0	1.000 / 1.000	0.0017 c_0	2.20 s	run (gas clearing)
0.1	0.951 / 0.755	0.0167 c_0 (tail model 0.0159)	8.26 s	extrapolated: tail $k_{des}\theta N_0 A/(Qc_0)$, θ decaying at 0.088 s^{-1}
1	0.660 / 0.113	0.0254 c_0 (tail model 0.0238)	4.33 s	extrapolated, θ decaying at 0.654 s^{-1}
10	0.163 / 0.001	0.0030 c_0	2.40 s	run (surface empties within 0.3 s; gas clearing again)

2.2 s) the three cycles are 6.2, 31.6 and 23.3 s. The rule turns this into a throughput formula,

$$\mathrm{WPH} = \frac{3600}{N\,[\,2 \times 1.2\,(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}})\,N_0/(Uc_0) + \mathrm{purges}\,] + \mathrm{handling}}, \tag{6}$$

with N the number of cycles: below a wall-area ratio of about 10 the purges set the cycle and precursor fraction buys little; above it throughput falls as $1/(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}})$, and tripling the

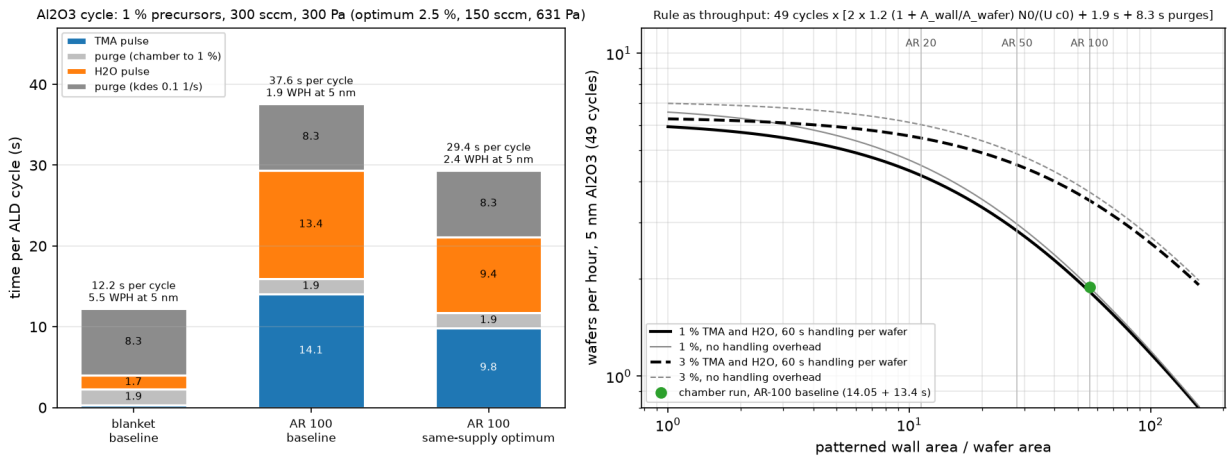


Figure 14: Left: the four segments of the Al_2O_3 cycle (TMA pulse, chamber purge to 1 %, H_2O pulse, purge at $k_{des} = 0.1\,s^{-1}$) stacked for the blanket baseline, the patterned AR-100 baseline and the same-supply optimum, with the cycle time and the 5 nm throughput (60 s handling) over each bar. Right: wafers per hour for 5 nm against wall-area ratio from the rule at 1 % and 3 % TMA, with and without 60 s handling, and the AR-100 chamber run as the point.

Table 7: Al_2O_3 cycle time and throughput (GPC 0.103 nm per cycle; 49 cycles for 5 nm, 98 for 10 nm). Purges: TMA 1.90 s (chamber outlet to 1 %, 20 s patterned run); H_2O 8.26 s ($k_{des} = 0.1\,s^{-1}$, a stated choice). In brackets: the same cycle with gas clearing only for water ($k_{des} = 0$, 2.20 s). WPH = wafers per hour.

Recipe	TMA + purge + H_2O + purge	Cycle	5 nm: min per wafer, WPH, WPH with 60 s handling	10 nm: min per wafer, WPH, WPH with 60 s handling
Blanket wafer, baseline (1 %, 300 sccm, 300 Pa, 15 mm)	0.345 + 1.90 + 1.74 + 8.26 s	12.2 s (6.2 s)	10.0 min, 6.0, 5.5 (5.1 min, 11.9, 9.9)	20.0 min, 3.0, 2.9 (10.1 min, 5.9, 5.4)
Patterned AR 100, baseline	14.05 + 1.90 + 13.4 + 8.26 s	37.6 s (31.6 s)	30.7 min, 1.95, 1.9 (25.8 min, 2.3, 2.2)	61.4 min, 0.98, 0.96 (51.5 min, 1.2, 1.1)
Patterned AR 100, same-supply optimum (2.51 %, 150 sccm, 631 Pa, 10 mm)	9.83 + 1.90 + 9.38 + 8.26 s	29.4 s (23.3 s)	24.0 min, 2.5, 2.4 (19.0 min, 3.2, 3.0)	48.0 min, 1.25, 1.2 (38.1 min, 1.6, 1.5)

TMA fraction doubles the AR-100 throughput (1.8 to 3.5 wafers per hour) while leaving the blanket wafer where it was (5.9 to 6.3), Table 8. The chamber run at AR 100 sits on the 1 % curve within 2 %.

3.11 A full 3D chamber with a one-sided pump

The wedge is axisymmetric by construction. To test what a real pumping arrangement does to the saturation map, the same chamber was meshed in full 3D (`blockMesh` O-grid, 106,000 hexahedra, non-orthogonality below 31°, 12 cells across the 15 mm gap) with the outlet reduced from the full annulus to a 60° sector of the side wall at $r = 200$ mm, the rest of the side wall a no-slip wall; showerhead, wafer condition, operating point and TMA fraction are those of Section 3.3 (uniform

Table 8: The rule as throughput: wafers per hour for 5 nm (49 cycles) against wall-area ratio, both half-cycles at the same supply flux, purges 1.90 + 8.26 s. Each cell gives cycle, WPH, WPH with 60 s handling, and in brackets the WPH with 60 s handling and the $k_{\mathrm{des}} = 0$ water purge.

$A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}}$	1 % TMA	3 % TMA
1	11.2 s, 6.6, 5.9 (11.6)	10.5 s, 7.0, 6.3 (13.0)
11.2 (AR 20)	16.3 s, 4.5, 4.2 (6.4)	12.2 s, 6.0, 5.5 (10.0)
28.0 (AR 50)	25.1 s, 2.9, 2.8 (3.6)	15.1 s, 4.9, 4.5 (7.1)
55.9 (AR 100)	39.3 s, 1.9, 1.8 (2.1)	19.9 s, 3.7, 3.5 (4.9)
112	67.6 s, 1.1, 1.1 (1.2)	29.3 s, 2.5, 2.4 (3.0)

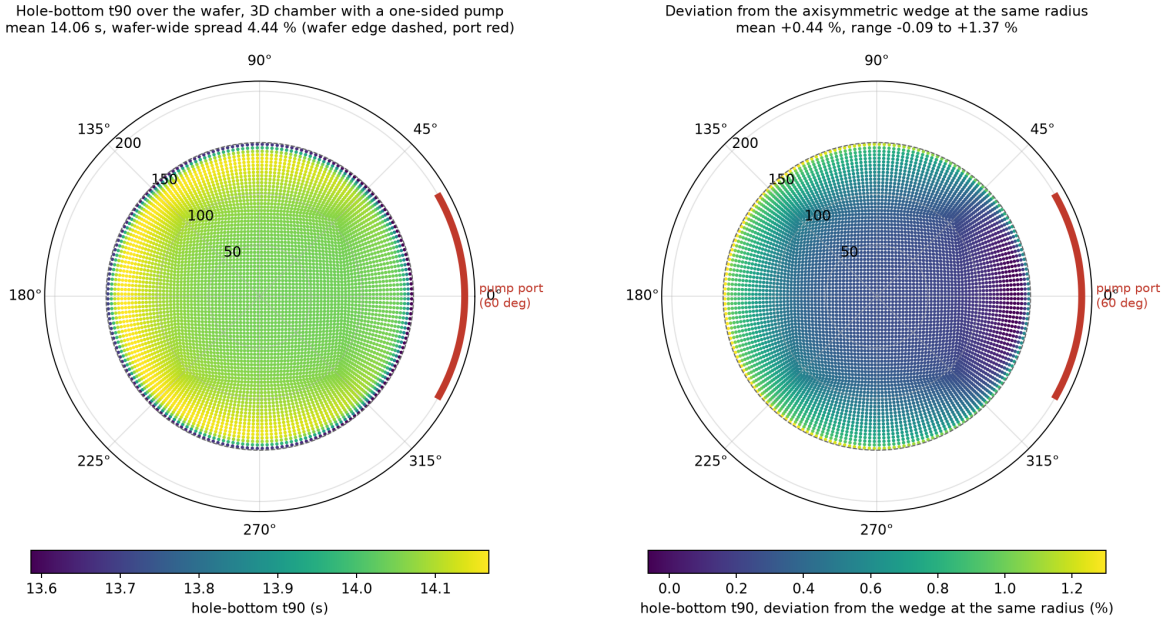


Figure 15: Full 3D chamber with a one-sided 60° pumping port: polar map of the hole-bottom t_{90} over the AR-100 wafer at the 6144 face centres (left, absolute; right, deviation from the wedge value at the same radius in %), the port marked in red at $r = 200$ mm, the wafer edge dashed.

AR-100 wafer, 1 % TMA, 16 s pulse). The steady carrier flow (Re = 0.045) is strongly one-sided: the gap-averaged outward velocity at $r = 140$ mm is 0.85 m/s in the port-side quadrant and 0.01 m/s on the far side, against 0.27 m/s in the axisymmetric chamber, so gas over the far half of the wafer crosses the wafer toward the port instead of leaving radially (Fig. 15).

The gas phase sees the asymmetry, the saturation time hardly does. At $r = 140$ mm the surface TMA density is 9 % higher on the port side than on the far side at 0.3 s and 8 % higher at 14 s, and the hole-bottom coverage at 14 s is 0.90 against 0.84; but the hole bottoms fill in a steep late wave fed by the integrated supply, so this 6 % coverage lead is a 0.13 s lead in saturation time. The azimuthal peak-to-peak of the hole-bottom t_{90} is 0.09 % at $r = 50$ mm, 0.37 % at 100 mm and 0.96 % at 140 mm, in every case a single smooth lobe earliest at the port and latest opposite it (Fig. 16, Table 9). The slowest point on the wafer moves from the edge ring of the wedge to the far side at $r = 133$ mm, 160° from the port, at 14.17 s against 14.05 s in the wedge, and 0.3 % of that 0.8 % is the coarser 3D gap resolution, which shifts the centre value by the same amount. The flat surface between the holes, which saturates at 2 s while the gas phase is still drawn down to 0.02 c_0,

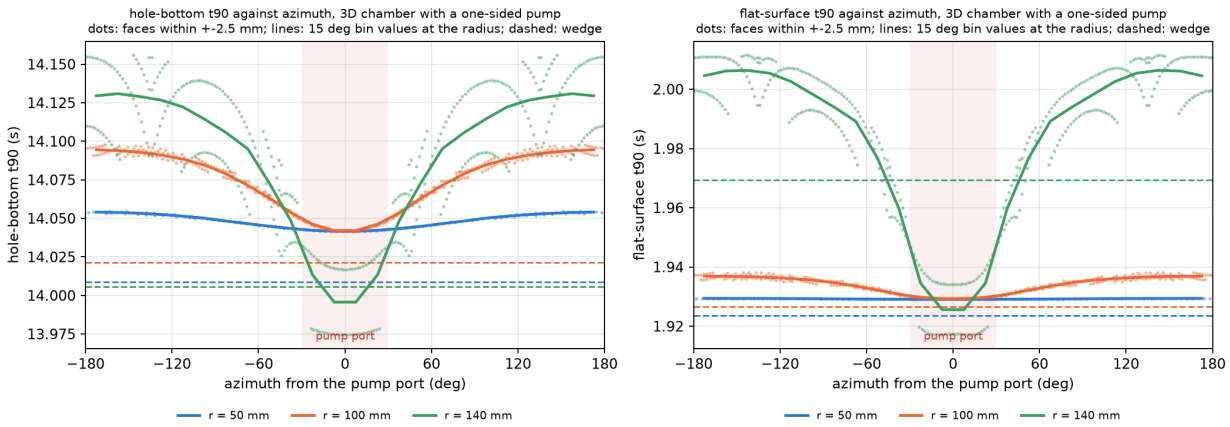


Figure 16: Hole-bottom (left) and flat-surface (right) t_{90} against azimuth from the port at $r = 50$, 100 and 140 mm in the 3D chamber: faces within ± 2.5 mm as dots, 15° bin values at the exact radius as lines, the wedge value at that radius dashed.

Table 9: Hole-bottom t_{90} in the 3D chamber by radius (0.9 crossing interpolated between 0.1 s writes; wedge values from the same interpolation on the 20 s AR-100 run; port at azimuth 0).

Radius (mm)	Faces	Mean (s)	Min (s)	Max (s)	Peak-to-peak, raw band (% of mean)	Peak-to-peak, 15° bins at the exact radius (%)	Port side − far side (%)	Wedge t_{90} at r (s)	3D mean / wedge
50	140	14.048	14.042	14.055	0.09	0.09	−0.08	14.009	1.0028
100	308	14.075	14.041	14.098	0.40	0.37	−0.36	14.021	1.0038
140	360	14.089	13.975	14.156	1.29	0.96	−0.90	14.006	1.0060
148.9 (outermost row)	248	13.687	13.544	13.931	2.83	–	−0.70	13.280 (r = 149.5 mm)	1.031

is the more sensitive indicator: 1.92 s on the port side against 2.01 s on the far side at $r = 140$ mm, a 4.8 % spread.

The reason is the one behind the whole paper. At gap Péclet 0.09 the precursor reaches the wafer by diffusion across the gap from the showerhead directly above each point, the patterned wafer captures almost all of what arrives, and the saturation time is the time to deliver $(1 + A_{\text{wall}}/A_{\text{wafer}})\, N_0$ per unit area at the showerhead's own rate. The cross-flow toward the port can redistribute only the few per cent that escape capture, and it does so over a lateral diffusion time ($R^2/D = 2.7$ s) short against the 14 s pulse. A one-sided pump therefore costs about 1 % of pulse time on this wafer; the recipe margin of the design rule (the factor 1.2) covers it, and the azimuthal lag would need a convective gap (Péclet of order 1, i.e. ten times the flow or pressure) before it mattered. The same ordering holds in the wedge's radial direction, where the edge lag is 0.4 %.

4 Discussion

- Throughput on patterned wafers is bought with precursor delivery rate (vapour pressure, bubbler carrier flow, injector design), not with chamber pressure, gap or carrier flow; those knobs move uniformity.

- Recipe transfer: the blanket-to-product factor is the wall-area ratio, 11 to 56 here; monitor-wafer recipes under-dose product wafers by that factor at the same supply.

- Precursor utilization: 60 % (TMA) and 50 % (H_2O) over the saturating pulse on the patterned wafer; the remainder is pumped after saturation. Shorter pulses with feedback (end-point on surface density) would recover it.

- The TMA sticking coefficient is the least certain input of the chamber model: the published values at or near this temperature span 0.5–2×10^{-3} (Arts et al. [5], lateral-high-aspect-ratio front slope at a 275 °C set-point), $(4 \pm 1) \times 10^{-3}$ (Vandalon and Kessels [22], sum-frequency generation at 300 °C), 5.72×10^{-3} (Ylilammi et al. [4], fit to a lateral channel profile at 300 °C) and 8.5×10^{-3} (this work, fit to the Zenodo 3974438 profiles [10] at 300 °C, factor 1.5 sheet-to-sheet). We reran the baseline operating point (1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 300 Pa, 573 K) at $s = 5 \times 10^{-4}$, 10^{-3}, 2×10^{-3}, 5×10^{-3} and 8.5×10^{-3} for the blanket wafer and the AR-100 patterned wafer (Fig. 17). On the patterned wafer the hole bottoms reach 90 % coverage at 14.00–14.15 s (centre) and 14.05–14.20 s (worst face) for every value, 1.17–1.18 times the supply-limit time of 11.99 s, with 84–85 % precursor utilization: a seventeen-fold change in s moves the saturating pulse by three write intervals. Low sticking changes the order of events inside the hole (at 10 s the bottom coverage is 0.38 at $s = 5 \times 10^{-4}$ and 0.02 at 8.5×10^{-3}) but not the finish, because the last tenth of the bottom coverage waits for molecules that the showerhead has not yet delivered. The design rule, the blanket-to-product transfer factor and the pulse-time map are therefore independent of which published value is right.

- The blanket wafer is not: low sticking is a conformality asset and a throughput cost only on blanket wafers. Its saturation time runs from 0.33 s at $s = 8.5 \times 10^{-3}$ to 1.01 s at 5×10^{-4}, about $s^{-0.4}$ rather than $1/s$, because the TMA density at the wafer rises as the uptake slows ($0.065\,c_0$ against $0.23\,c_0$ at the centre 0.1 s into the pulse) and partly compensates; the flat surface between the holes of the patterned wafer behaves the same way (1.55 to 6.00 s). Every blanket-wafer time in this paper therefore carries a factor-3 uncertainty from the sticking coefficient, whereas the patterned-wafer times carry only the site-density uncertainty of the supply limit. The 8.5×10^{-3} of our PillarHall fit is a slope-constrained value: the front slope fixes s and the penetration depth fixes the exposure per site, so the unknown TMA partial pressure trades against the assumed site density, not against s. It sits a factor 1.5 to 2 above the two other 300 °C values and a factor 4 above the upper bound of the 275 °C set-point data, a spread that also reflects three different kinetic definitions (initial sticking probability, lumped Langmuir coefficient with an equilibrium constant, irreversible first-order Langmuir on 4×10^{18} sites). A profile grown at a known TMA partial pressure at 300 °C, with the site density taken from the measured growth per cycle, would remove the trade-off and fix s to the sheet-to-sheet scatter.

- Robustness checks: replacing the bare floor by a 25 mm edge ring with pumping below the wafer plane changes no saturation time by more than one write interval and leaves the within-wafer spread within 3 % (blanket 9–11 %, patterned 4 %), Fig. 18; the pulse-time results do not depend on the chamber outboard of the wafer at this Péclet number.

- Robustness checks continued: 200, 300 and 400 °C at fixed sccm and feed fraction give the same pulse times within one write interval (the supply Uc_0 is temperature-independent; temperature acts through the chemistry, held fixed here); 50, 100 and 200 nm holes at fixed open area and aspect ratio saturate within 1 % of each other, so the wall-area ratio is the rule's only geometric input.

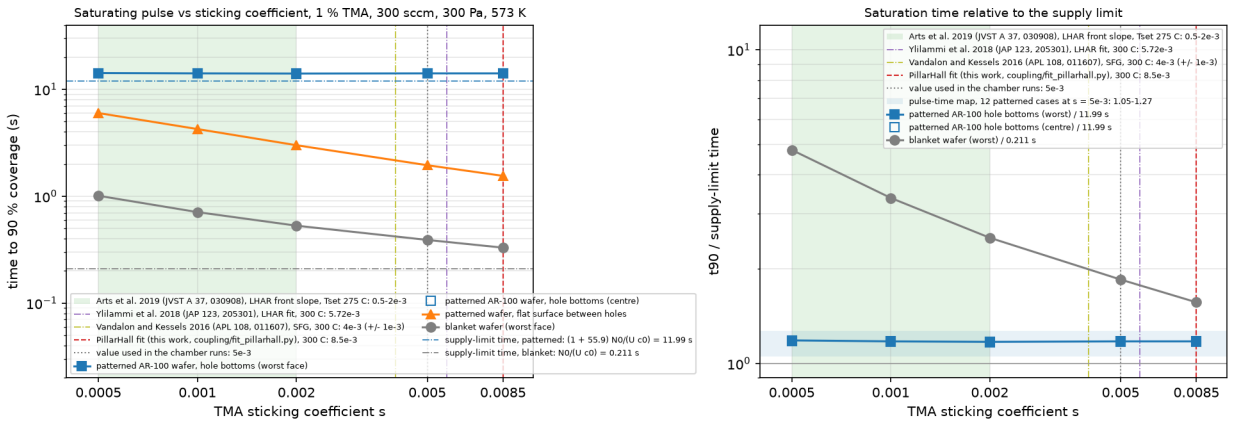


Figure 17: Sensitivity of the saturating TMA pulse to the sticking coefficient at the baseline operating point (1 % TMA, 300 sccm, 300 Pa, 573 K, 15 mm gap). Left: time to 90 % coverage against s for the blanket wafer (worst face), the flat surface between the holes of the AR-100 patterned wafer, and the hole bottoms of the patterned wafer (centre and worst face); dash-dotted horizontal lines are the supply-limit times $(1 + 55.9)\, N_0/(Uc_0) = 11.99\,\mathrm{s}$ and $N_0/(Uc_0) = 0.211\,\mathrm{s}$. Right: the same times divided by their supply-limit time; the blue band is the 1.05–1.27 range of the twelve patterned cases of the pulse-time map at $s = 5 \times 10^{-3}$. In both panels the green band is the Arts et al. [5] range ($0.5–2\times10^{-3}$, set-point 275 °C), and the vertical lines are the Ylilammi et al. [4] fit (5.72×10^{-3}, 300 °C), the Vandalon and Kessels [22] sum-frequency-generation value (4×10^{-3}, 300 °C), the PillarHall fit of this work (8.5×10^{-3}, 300 °C) and the value used in the chamber runs (5×10^{-3}).

- Limitations: isothermal gas (temperature enters only through properties); frozen carrier flow; irreversible Langmuir in the main runs; a first-order desorption term was added for water and shows the purge-tail mechanism (desorbing water holds the exhaust above 1 % for seconds at $k_{\mathrm{des}} = 0.1$ to $1\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$) and the equilibrium-coverage limit (above $\sim 0.3\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$ at 1 % H_2O the surface never reaches 90 %), Fig. 7, but k_{des} is a parameter, not a measurement, and a two-site chemisorbed/physisorbed model is the next step; single pattern density (14 % open area, half the wafer patterned); Knudsen $D_K = d\bar{v}/3$ without Clausing correction; s and N_0 are literature-range inputs (the sensitivity to s is quantified above; the patterned-wafer times carry only the site-density uncertainty).

5 Conclusions

1. On a patterned wafer, the ALD pulse that saturates the deepest feature is set by precursor supply:

$$t_{\mathrm{pulse}} = 1.2\left(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}}\right)\frac{N_0}{Uc_0}, \tag{7}$$

within 25 % over aspect ratios 20–100 and a twenty-fold range of feed fraction, and independent of hole diameter at fixed wall area, of temperature at fixed sccm and fraction, of the chamber geometry outboard of the wafer, of the TMA sticking coefficient across its published range (5×10^{-4} to 8.5×10^{-3}: 1.17 to 1.18 supply-limit times, three write intervals of movement)

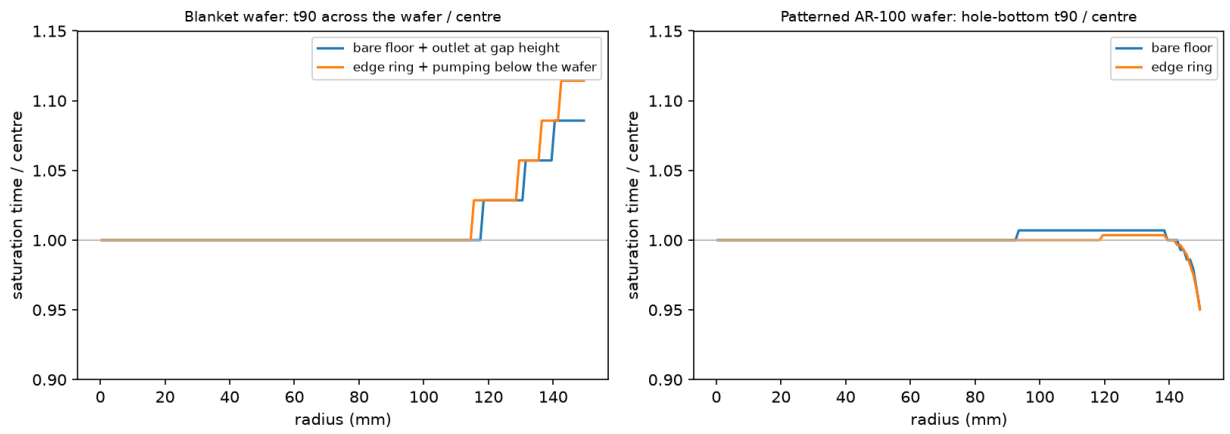


Figure 18: Robustness to the chamber geometry outboard of the wafer, baseline conditions, 1 % TMA. Saturation time across the wafer divided by its value at the centre for the bare floor with the outlet at gap height and for a 25 mm non-absorbing edge ring with the pumping slot 25 mm below the wafer plane. Left: blanket wafer. Right: hole-bottom saturation on the patterned AR-100 wafer. The two geometries differ by at most one write interval.

and, in a full 3D chamber with a one-sided pump, of the pumping arrangement (azimuthal spread of the saturation time under 1 %, within the rule's factor 1.2).

2. The same normalisation puts a measured fluidized-bed ALD run at 1.12 supply-limit times and orders the measured utilization of a rotary-drum reactor with loading; wafers and powders sit on one curve of utilization against surface area spanning five orders of magnitude.

3. The chamber model reproduces the published Fiji F200 case where that case can be represented: the TMA exposure delivered to the wafer per pulse agrees with the authors' three-dimensional CFD to 12 to 22 % and the saturation state of the 25 and 60 ms pulses with the measured growth per cycle; the 2.4 % measured non-uniformity, which comes from an off-axis pulse recirculation, a cold loading door and softer-than-Langmuir kinetics, is not reproduced by an axisymmetric frozen-flow model. The blanket saturation exposure, 0.146 Pa s at the surface, sits inside the 0.05 to 1.3 Pa s spread of kinetic saturation exposures from seven independent sources.

4. A recipe saturated on a blanket wafer under-doses a product wafer by the wall-area ratio, 11 to 56 here. Blanket wafers are the kinetics-limited exception to the rule, not the norm.

5. On a non-uniform layout the pulse is set by the local wall-area ratio of the most demanding region, not by the wafer average: the average under-predicts by 2.3× (dense centre) and 1.2× (aspect-ratio ramp), the local ratio is conservative by 15 to 21 %, and a pattern boundary puts a 26 % saturation gradient inside the array.

6. Second-order knobs: pressure up and carrier flow down raise precursor utilization from about 55 % to 95 % at fixed precursor flow; gap and pressure set within-wafer edge lag (5 to 18 %) but not time.

7. The water half-cycle needs the same pulse as TMA on patterned wafers despite a 50× lower sticking coefficient, and coats deep features more evenly; reversible adsorption, not chamber flushing, governs its purge.

8. In fab units the rule's pulse gives 99 % step coverage as well as 90 %, because the saturation front is 0.25 to 0.3 s wide at every aspect ratio; 50 cycles of the blanket recipe leave 1.4 nm of a 5.15 nm film on top of an AR-100 array and nothing at the bottom. The Al_2O_3 cycle on the AR-100 wafer is 3.1 times the blanket cycle (37.6 against 12.2 s; 1.9 against 5.5 wafers per hour for 5 nm), its pulses are three quarters of the cycle, and above a wall-area ratio of about 10 throughput falls as $1/(1 + A_{\mathrm{wall}}/A_{\mathrm{wafer}})$; the purge is set by water desorption, not by the chamber, which clears to 1 % in 2 s while a 10 μm hole empties in microseconds.

9. Plasma ALD adds a hard ceiling: above a wall recombination probability of about 3×10^{-3}, aspect ratio 100 is unreachable by dose. Separated-chemistry (spatial) architectures beat temporal pulsing by the same wall-area factor the rule predicts.

10. All of this runs on a laptop in open-source tools, with the feature model verified against an independent code and fitted to public measurements, and every number traceable to a script in the repository.

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Validation data by R. L. Puurunen and O. M. E. Ylivaara (Aalto University, Zenodo 3974438, CC BY 4.0). Machball by A. Yanguas-Gil and J. W. Elam (Argonne). OpenFOAM v2606 (OpenCFD) via the gerlero/openfoam-app build.

Code and data availability

OpenFOAM v2606 cases, the `aldWallKinetics` boundary-condition library, the Python `aldconf` solver and its command line (`python -m aldconf` evaluates the rule, the surrogate and the Pareto front), tests and all figures: `https://github.com/Soham-ChemE/ald-conformality`. The repository also ships a layout-to-recipe tool on its live page (pattern zones in, per-zone local rule and recipe pulse out, calibrated on the two non-uniform runs of Section 3.9) and continuous integration that rebuilds the boundary conditions and reruns a regression case in an OpenFOAM container (77 tests). Validation data: Zenodo 3974438 (CC BY 4.0).

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